

Yanlin Wan

yanlin.wan@connect.ust.hk ◇ +86 18818407990 ◇ LinkedIn ◇ <https://yanlinwan.github.io/>

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EDUCATION

The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology

Phd, Individualized Interdisciplinary Program

Hongkong SAR

2021 - 2026 Expected

Bocconi University

MSc, Economic and Social Sciences

Milan, Italy

2018 - 2020

Beijing Forestry University

BMgt, Accounting

Beijing, China

2014 - 2018

RESEARCH INTEREST

Development Economics, Behavioral Economics

WORKING PAPERS

Closing the Treatment Gap in Mental Healthcare: Evidence from China

with Yuzhi Hao, Xu Zhang

- **Abstract:** We evaluate a large-scale, nationwide policy in China that aimed to improve population mental well-being by simultaneously expanding the supply of mental healthcare resources and reducing public stigma. Using a difference-in-differences design, we find that the policy significantly improved mental health outcomes on average; however, the benefits were concentrated among individuals with better mental health. We then provide descriptive evidence of an increase in mental healthcare adoption following this policy. To investigate the channels driving this enhanced adoption, we conducted a discrete choice experiment (DCE) focusing on the costs of care: monetary costs (price), time costs (commuting time), and psychological costs (stigma). The DCE reveals crucial heterogeneity: individuals with better mental health are more responsive to reductions in time costs but less sensitive to monetary costs. These findings suggest the policy's average success was driven by the reduced time costs for these with better mental health conditions. We conclude that effective mental health interventions require a broad approach to improve general access, coupled with targeted efforts to remove financial barriers and provide privacy-sensitive support for those with severe conditions.

AI Policy in Education: A Randomized Control Experiment

with Jinghao Jia, Xu Zhang

- **Abstract:** We investigate the optimal design of institutional rules for integrating Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) into middle school education. Using a Randomized Controlled Trial (RCT) across two urban middle schools in China, we causally estimate the effects of two policy components: AI Guidance (providing instructional information) and AI Conditional Use (a policy-imposed restriction on the AI rate in writing). While we find a insignificant average treatment effect on academic performance, the interventions yield significant heterogeneous effects by gender. Specifically, the Conditional Use restriction generated a positive academic spillover: female students experienced substantial improvement in math scores, with the largest causal benefit observed in the combined Guidance and Conditional Use group. We propose that this differential impact is driven by a compliance mechanism. Descriptive evidence shows that girls, who had higher baseline AI engagement, demonstrated greater adherence to the guidelines during the experiment, successfully steering their engagement toward more productive AI tool use. This suggests that the combination of guidance and use restriction is a powerful, gender-specific intervention that leverages existing student self-regulation to realize positive returns from AI.

Nudge for Sanitation: Experimental Evidence from China

with Xu Zhang

- **Summary:** Uses a Randomized Controlled Trial (RCT) to test the behavioral impact of six informational nudges on participation in China's rural sanitation reforms. Findings show that while any relevant information increases willingness, highlighting benefits or harms is most effective for long-term enrollment decisions, but only among subjects with higher initial program knowledge. Furthermore, the study finds a null effect of low-intensity peer influence (messenger effect), which suggests that policy interventions must address both knowledge barriers and cultural inertia to promote widespread adoption in anti-poverty campaigns. (Submitted)

Rewiring Opportunity: How Improved Internet Infrastructure Reduces Intra-City Income Inequality in China

with Xu Zhang, Yuzhi Hao, Aoqing Lyu, Masaru Yarime

- **Summary:** Employs staggered difference-in-differences to show that China's Broadband China Strategic Program significantly reduced intra-city income inequality by creating service sector employment opportunities for low skilled workers, particularly in logistics, with measurable income gains among low- and middle-income households. (Submitted)

Risk tolerance, soft skills, and sectoral sorting: Experimental Evidence from India

with Raja Rajendra Timilsina, Dil B Rahut, Tetsushi Sonobe

- **Summary:** Uses a lab-in-the-field experiment in urban India to investigate occupational sorting in dual labor markets. Findings reveal that sorting into digital vs. non-digital informal sectors reflects heterogeneous preferences over income risk, self-control, and openness, rather than simple technological adoption. Specifically, younger non-digital workers show higher risk tolerance, while digital workers exhibit greater self-control. The results formalize labor market segmentation and inform the design of risk-sharing and skill-building policies for future platform scalability. (Submitted)

SELECTED WORKS IN PROGRESS

- Demand for Social Security Program among Informal Workers in Urban India (with Raja Rajendra Timilsina, Dil B Rahut, Ngawang Dendup, Tetsushi Sonobe)
- Digital Divide and Financial Inclusion Paradigm: Case Study of Indonesia and Bangladesh (with Arief Ramayandi, Dil B Rahut, Ngawang Dendup, Raja Rajendra Timilsina)

PRESENTATIONS

2025: Asian Development Bank Economist Forum; *International Research Society for Public Management Conference; *Atlanta Conference on Science and Innovation Policy; Asian Economic Development Conference; Asian Development Bank Institute Conference on Innovations for Sustainable Agriculture and Rural Development; The Behavioral Science in Action (BeSA) Conference 2025 at Peking University

2024: Xiamen University International Workshops on Experimental Economics; Asian Economic Development Conference; Technology, Data, and Policy Conference at Massachusetts Institute of Technology; HKUST(Guangzhou) IPE Seminar

2023: North America Meetings of Economic Science Association; Asian Pacific Public Policy Network; HKUST(Guangzhou) IPE Seminar

2022: *ShenZhen University Public Policy and Experimental Economics Workshop; *Annual Conference on Chinese Development Theory at Renmin University of China

*indicates presentation by a coauthor

AWARDS

2021-2025: Postgraduate Scholarship, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology

2025: Honorable Mention, Asian Development Bank-International Economic Association Innovative Policy Research Award

2023: First Prize, Graduate Students Development Economics Conference University of Chinese Academy of Social Sciences; Research Travel Grant

2020: Fondo Sostegno Giovani and International Organization Scholarship, Bocconi University

OTHER RESEARCH EXPERIENCES

United Nations Industrial Development Organization

Brussels, Belgium

Policy Research Intern

02/2020 – 07/2020

- Supervisor: Patrick Gilabert
- Participate in the study and analysis of the EU's fundamental policy areas related to UNIDO mandate
- Provide analytical support to UN House Working Group on Green Deal and project managers
- The report titled *The EU Global Response to COVID-19* is available at UNIDO website

Beijing Forestry University

Research Assistant

Beijing, China

12/2014 - 12/2015

- Supervisor: Dahong Zhang
- Literature review and data collection for the research project titled *Research on Ecological Safety Index (ESI)*

TEACHING EXPERIENCES

Spring 2023: Behavioral Economics and Public Policy (Graduate)

Fall 2022: Experimental Economics and Organizational Behavior (Graduate)

SKILLS

Programming: Stata, LaTeX, ArcGIS, R, Python

Language: Chinese(Native), English(Fluent), Italian(Basic)

REFEREES

Assistant Professor Dr.Xu Zhang

Society Hub, The Hongkong University of Science and Technology (Guangzhou)

✉ xuzhang@hkust-gz.edu.cn

Associate Professor Dr.Masaru Yarime

Division of Public Policy, The Hongkong University of Science and Technology

✉ yarime@ust.hk

Assistant Professor Dr.Zihan Hu

Department of Economics, Singapore Management University

✉ zihanhu@smu.edu.sg

Vice Chair of Research & Senior Research Economist Dr.Dil Rahut

Research Department, Asian Development Bank Institute

✉ drahut@adbi.org